

Negotiating entertainment commodities invested in

An observation on the discursive functioning of movie trailers and community trailer re-cuts

Notes on a methodology to understand substantial experiences in a digital world

Materialities of communication understood as “the totality of phenomena contributing to the constitution of meaning without being meaning themselves.” (Gumbrecht and Pfeiffer 1994: 398). Put analytically, **reconstructing the structures and processes by which meaning can be articulated.**

**Cultural
properties**

↕

**Cultural
Moods**

↕

**Affective
engagement**

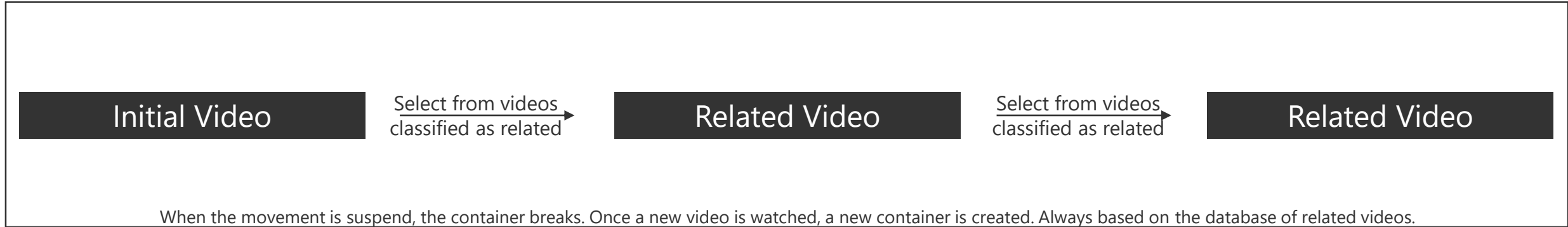
Identities, meanings, or other cultural properties understood as structures that seek to stabilize certain orderings of the world (Breiger 2007, Ikegami 2000, 2005, Fontdevila et al. 2011, Fuhse 2009, Mützel 2009).

Culturally and historically specific feelings of life and living. Reoccurring patterns of being touched by one's surrounding environment (Gumbrecht 1997, 2004, 2013, 2014).

Broadly understood as implication within the larger ecological becoming of the world where human remains one among many elements (Hansen 2004a, 2004b, 2006, 2015).

- They are emergent from practices of connection or implication.
 - They seek to control or inform the creativity necessary to negotiate certain orderings of the world under changing environmental conditions.
 - They are the structures that seek to enable "new presencings of sensibility in the future." (Hansen 2015: 25).
-
- Mediate between reason and emotion (Inspiration of the mind and an activation of the body).
 - Functioning through spatio-temporal arrangements, repeatedly shape and condition experiences of living and reliving life (Sublime and overwhelming processes in which contingency becomes order, being in and holding onto the things of the world).
 - Feeling of aliveness in states of high emotional and bodily awareness (Being lost in focused intensity / Being touched from the inside).
-
- Technically exposing the ground upon which life (re)emerges.
 - Mediates pre-individual and individual being by bring in something exterior.
 - Feeding forward this information, this sensibility into individual phenomenal appearances.
 - Embodied experience highlighting not selection of relevant information but implication into presence and rhythms of audio-visibility.

Audio-visual container



**Algorithmically ordered chain of videos that are classified as related
and available on the platform.**

or

**Assemblage in which people, machines, and audio-visual contents
interact and upon which cultural properties (can) emerge.**

Investment in Entertainment Commodities

As revenue streams become more diverse, “audience creation has become just as important a creative product as the film itself.” (Epstein 2010, 174ff.). **People need to become invested in an entertainment commodity.**

These investments have a constitutive material and pragmatic dimension (Thevenot 2012). They emerge on the grounds of substantial experiences. Are then sought to be stabilized in the second place through collective beliefs and representations. Shaping reality, but also creating material structures and forms that seek to make substantial experiences possible again in the first place.

"We are witnessing the transformation of amateur film culture ... toward a focus on mastering the mechanisms for publicity and promotion, from a focus on self-documentation toward a focus on an aesthetic based on appropriation, parody, and the dialogic.

"Coppola's 'little fat girl' has found a way to talk back to the dominant media culture, to express herself not simply within an idiolect but within a shared language constructed through the powerful images and narratives that constitute contemporary popular culture.

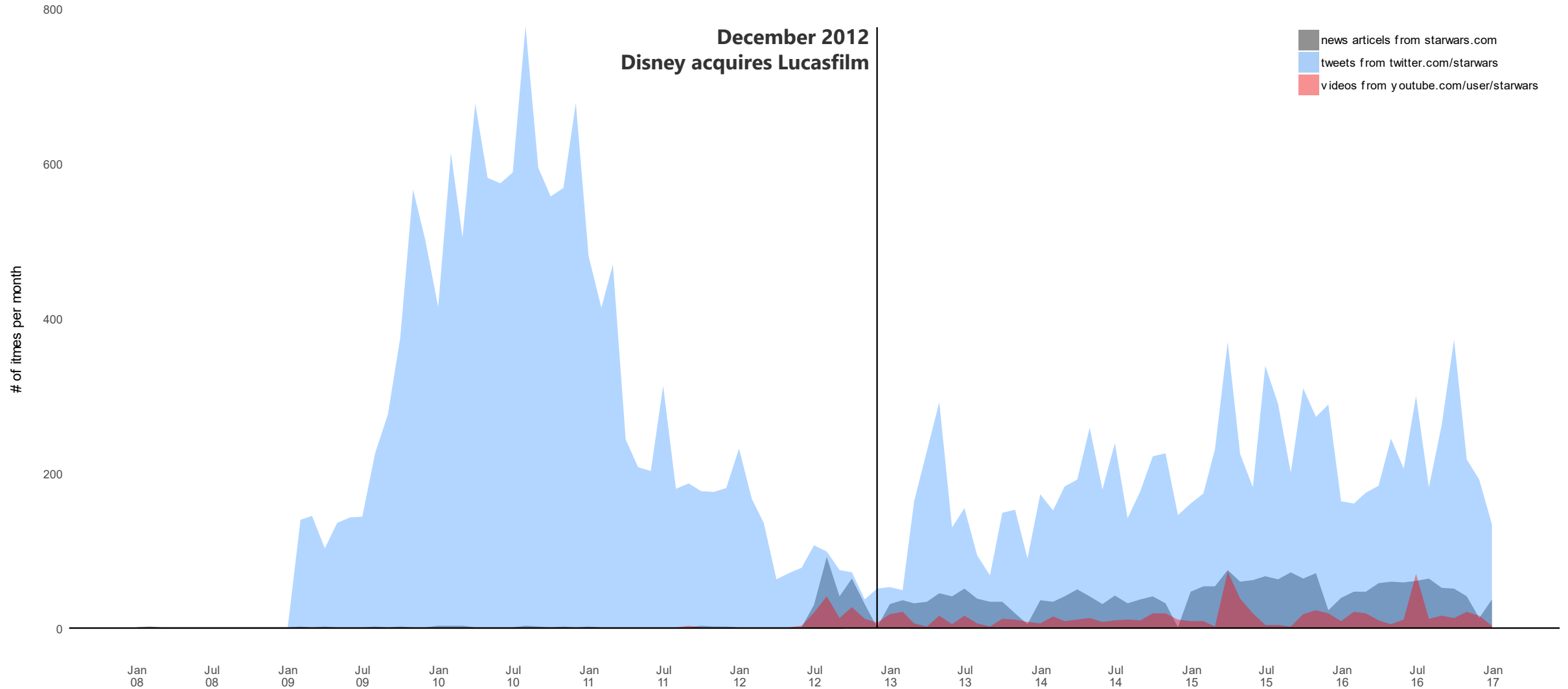
"[O]nly if we maintain a vigorous and effective defense of the principle of 'fair use,' only if we recognize the rights of consumers to participate fully, actively, and creatively within their own culture, and only if we hold in check the desires of the culture industries to tighten their control over their own intellectual property in response to the economic opportunities posed by an era of media convergence." (Jenkins 2003).

This view allows us to understand what linked ecologies (Abbott 2005) are at and can be at work in the entertainment commodities invested in today. Yet while new formats and properties emerge around movies, movie trailers remain a vital source in the process of becoming and remaining invested in a commodity over time. **Movie trailers, in their formats and distribution, form a material ground, a spectacle along which people can make substantial experiences** – coordinate personality and communality.

As such grounds increasingly emerge in digital settings, we have to **understand the role of algorithms not simply as finite set of rules achieving a goal but equipped with agency and materiality**. They observe and adapt, classify and order, are adapted and changed. Most importantly they are implemented on servers, have a runtime operation creating an affective presence on the platform (MacKenzie 2016, Parisi 2013, Passoth 2017).

How do you awaken a franchise?

Number of official Star Wars news articles, tweets, and YouTube videos over time





"Ron Howard Steps in to Direct Han Solo Movie"
(THR, Jun 2017)

"Disney Apparently Expects 'Solo: A Star Wars Story' To Bomb"
(Screengeeks, Dec 2017)

"Why Do Some Star Wars Fans Want the Han Solo Movie to Flop?"
(Vulture, Feb 2018)

"Solo: A Star Wars Story Actor Shares New Details About the Troubled Production"
(Vulture, Mar 2018)

"'Solo': How Big a Box Office Dud Is the 'Star Wars' Spinoff?"
(Variety, May 2018)

"'Star Wars' Fatigue Is a Myth (but Disney's Mistakes Were Real, Costly and Avoidable)"
(REDEF, Jun 2018)

Movie trailers and community re-cuts

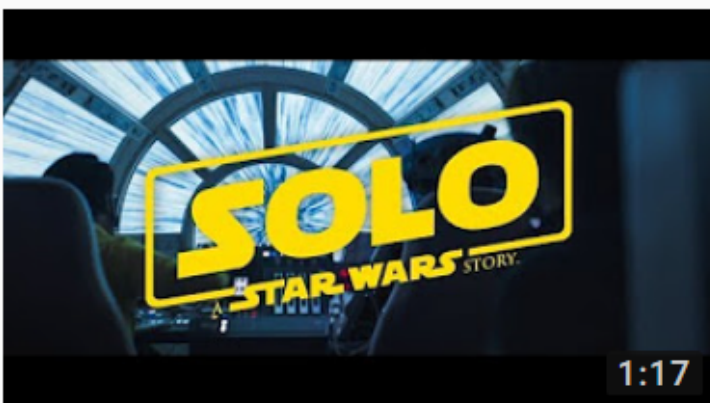


Solo: A Star Wars Story Official Trailer

Star Wars ✓ 17M views • 7 months ago

Watch the new trailer for Solo: A Star Wars Story and see it in theaters May 25. Visit Star Wars at <http://www.starwars.com> ...

Subtitles



Solo: A Star Wars Story - Sabotage Trailer Re-Cut

War Starts at Midnight Podcast • 969K views • 9 months ago

Because the first trailer felt an awful lot like "Solo: A James Tiberius Kirk Story" "Sabotage" - Beastie Boys Edited by Chris Galegar ...



- Introduces main themes of Han Solo/Story through signification.
- Introduces known characters establishing new narrative ties within the fictional universe.
- Focusses on the relationship between Han Solo and Chewbacca through humours encounters.
- At the end moves more towards fast edit and more adventurous mood.
- Music feels awkwardly keyed compared to other Star Wars scores.
- Communicates the overall mood of a fun movie yet low intensity.



- Fast edit and continuous movement of images.
- Focus on Han Solo entirely, no other characters introduced.
- Strong absence of language and 'direct' signification.
- Uses Beastie Boys' Sabotage as sound and edited according to that rhythm.
- Communicates the overall mood of an adventurous movie.
- Trailer is made resistant to interpretation. There is nothing really new we learn from it, but rather are reactivated a feeling already known.

Notes on method:

Data gathering:

- YouTube Data v3 API (public access)
- Top seeds for the search query 'solo star wars story trailer' (same results as when using native search via web interface)
- Related videos info for depths 0 and 1 (meaning, get related videos for initial seeds, depth 0, 1, for which again get related videos)

Network analysis:

Cluster through Louvain community detection algorithm (Blondel et al. 2008)

- Assumption is that YouTube creates relations based on similarity.
- Louvain algorithm generates clusters by optimizing communities towards densely connected nodes.
- Commonly used and reliable community detection method to gain first insight into composition of large networks (Lancichinetti and Fortunato 2011, Papadopoulos et al. 2011, Orman et al. 2012).

Force-directed layout with scaled gravity

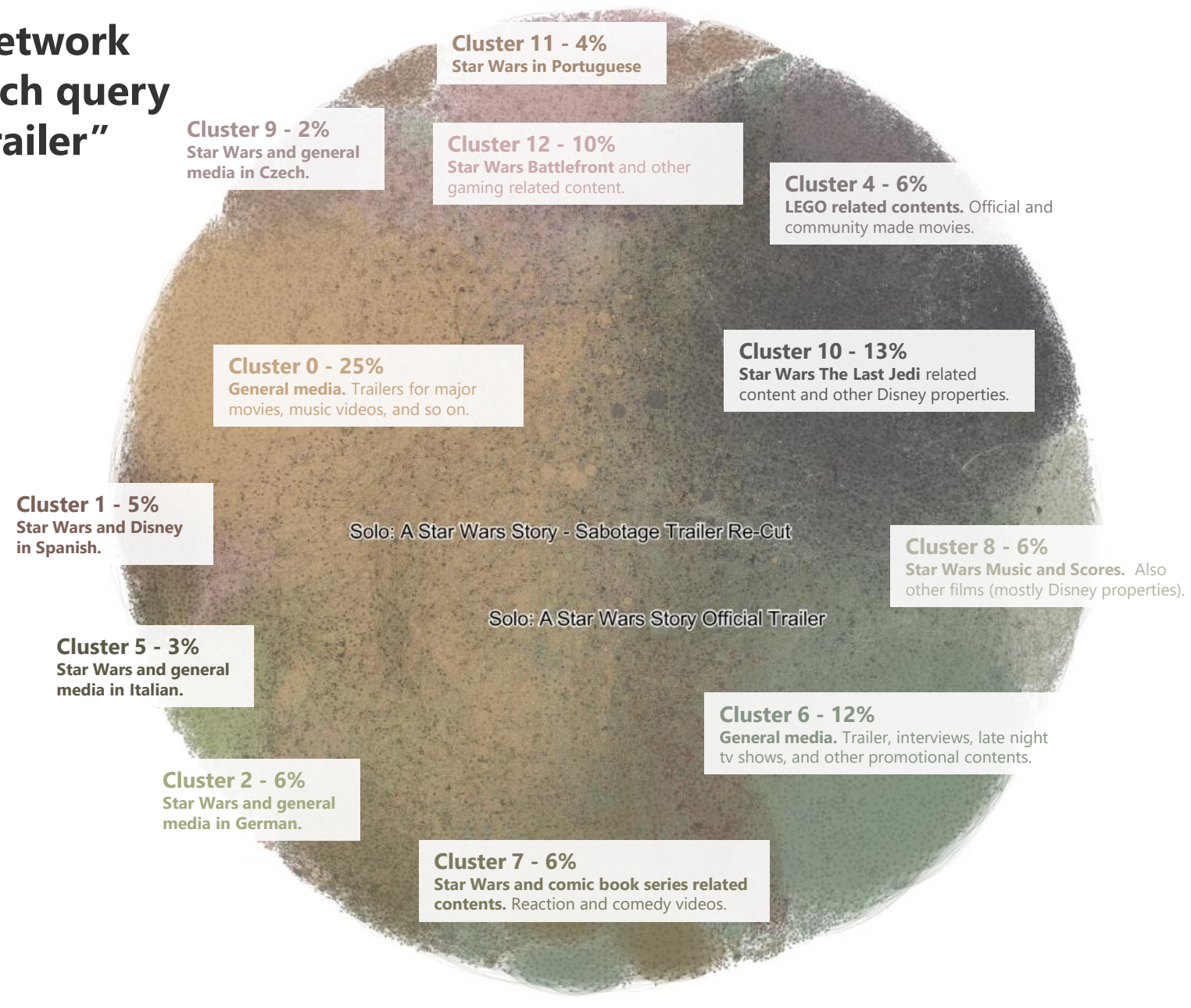
- Central nodes are placed centrally, cluster behave accordingly, gravity scaling enhances this by more compact and comparable spatialization (Bannister et al. 2013).

Content analysis:

Computationally supported content analysis (DiMaggio et al. 2013, Fuhse and Mützel 2011, Mützel 2015, Lewis et al. 2013, Lucas et al. 2015)

- Assessing themes of clusters through analysis of video titles and video tags (most operable considering size).
- (1) Inductive categorization of lower and upper bound of central (betweenness centrality) and influential nodes (view count and engagement ratio).
- (2) Extraction of central terms through analysis of co-occurrences (Deerwester et al. 1990, Lund and Burgess 1996) by using a graph based ranking model (Mihalcea and Tarau 2004).
- (3) Structural topic modelling for each corpus of video titles with centrality and influence measures as covariates (Roberts et al. 2013)

Related videos network for YouTube search query “solo star wars trailer”



Nodes	43851
Edges	377274
Clustering coefficient	.12
Average degree	16.60
Diameter	24
Range clustering coefficient within clusters	.13 / .27
Clusters / colour by	Louvain
Node size by	Betweenness
Layout	ForceAtlas2

Videos that directly connect community and official trailer



Young Han Solo Audition Tapes - CONAN on TBS

Team Coco ✓ 5.6M views • 2 years ago

Before Alden Ehrenreich nabbed the part, every actor worth their salt tried out to play the "Star Wars" smuggler. You were THIS ...

Subtitles



What Mark Hamill Thinks Of 'Solo: A Star Wars Story' (Exclusive)

Entertainment Tonight ✓ 547K views • 9 months ago

'The Last Jedi' star spoke to ET at the AARP Movies for Grownups Awards about the divisiveness surrounding 'Star Wars,' and ...



STAR WARS 8 The Last Jedi Characters In Real Life

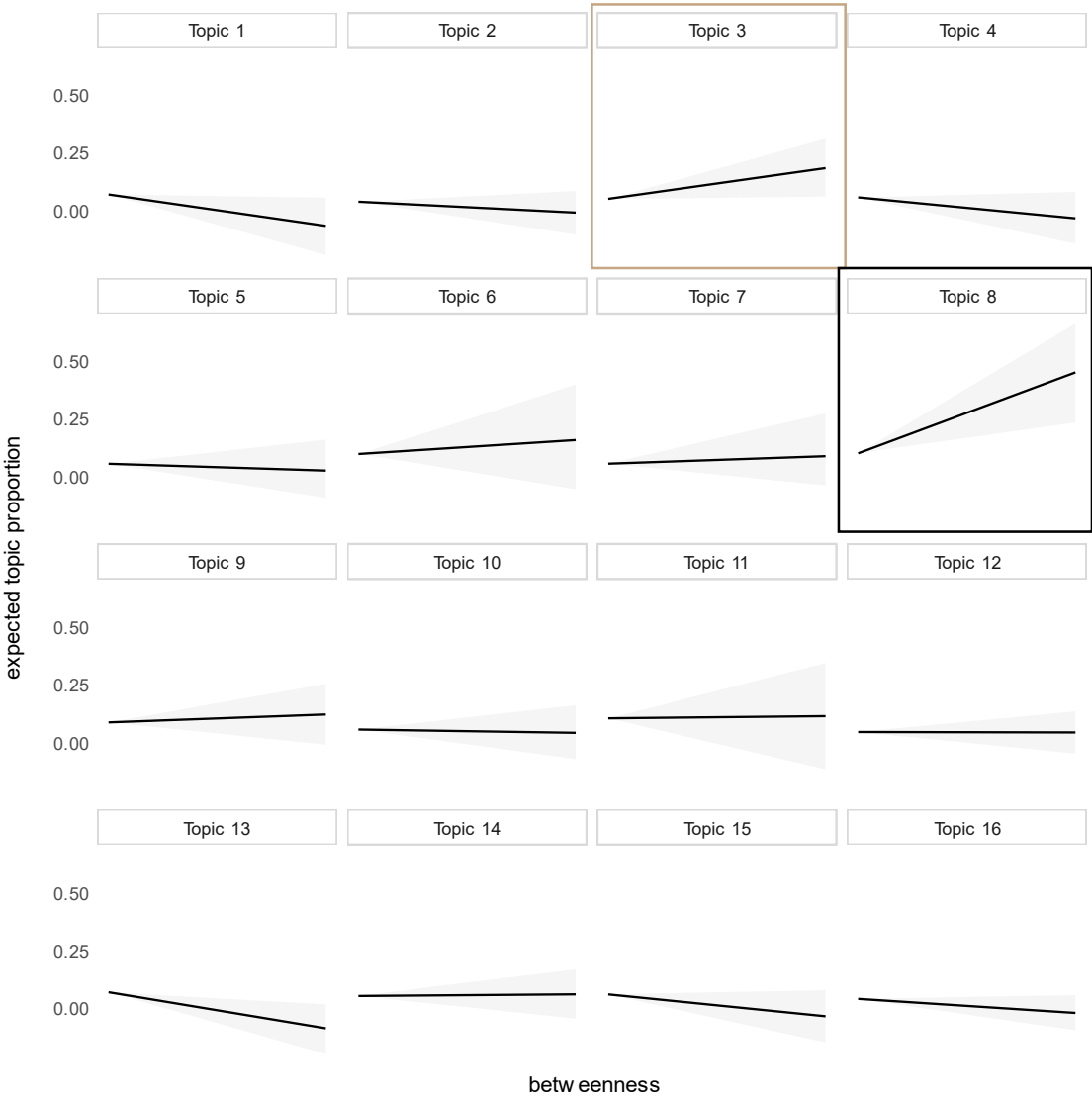
TheScreen • 12M views • 12 months ago

Subscribe to our channel: <https://goo.gl/rx6uZg> Like TheStuff on Facebook!
<https://www.facebook.com/thestufftv> Having taken her ...

Effects of betweenness centrality on topic distribution for Cluster 0 (community trailer)

Topic 3 features movie trailers for the coming seasons and especially next year. These videos are being placed more centrally by the algorithm.

Topics that are less centrally placed (1, 4, 13, 15, 16) share that they follow similar genres that could be associated with Star Wars. 1 and 13 Sci-Fi, 4 and 15 Adventure, 16 Fantasy.



The community trailer recut is placed in Topic 8. It features recent trailers of many major studio productions. The algorithm places these videos centrally.

“The target of control is not the production of subjects whose behaviours express internalized social norms; rather, control aims at a never-ending modulation of moods, capacities, affects, and potentialities, assembled in genetic codes, identification numbers, ratings profiles, and preference listings, that is to say, in bodies of data and information.” (Clough 2007: 19).

Notions of control on social media

R

5 months ago

yo, comment bots, why did it flop?

45 1 REPLY

X

5 months ago (edited)

I smell Disney bots on here! Because a whole bunch of P.R.-marketing type comments just popped up in the last 24 hours that look suspicious.

193 1 REPLY

View 15 replies

D

7 months ago

I'm legit dying over the fact that the marketing team thought to hint that chewbacca might die. In a prequel. That no one wanted.

644 1 REPLY

View 17 replies

F

7 months ago

What an odd final shot for the trailer. We know Chewbacca is going to be just fine. Trailer was good besides that. Still think this film is pointless but I am also an incredibly weak person and will see it day 1.

506 1 REPLY

View 29 replies

Notions of control in movie trailers

J

2 months ago

The new star wars moives are Soo bad and click bait..

3 1 REPLY

Q

5 months ago

There's a lot of shill fake accounts hyping this movie 🤔🤔🤔

19 1 REPLY

View 6 replies

E

5 months ago

Wonder if Kathleen Kennedy cares about Star Wars fans opinions now?

2 1 REPLY

T

5 months ago

yawn.. Hollywood could not make new content if they wanted to. How about something original that tells a great story. So tired of the flash and zero content.

3 1 REPLY

Y

2 months ago

Too much positive comments.

5 1 REPLY

N

Obi-wan fan

2 1

Notions of control in the franchise

V

5 months ago

Everyone being like "this is just fanservice" or "nobody needs this movie" or "the story is too thin".... Everything about Star Wars is fanservice, nobody "needed" Rogue One either and this story is finally NOT about the fate of the galaxy and the mysteries of the force. And thats what makes it so incredibly enjoyable to watch! Show less

U

2 months ago

Neckbeards are angry because people enjoyed this movie instead of joining the boycott movement they started at their mom's basement. "pOsItIvE cOmMeNt BoTs :Dd"

7 1

L

5 months ago

Loved the movie

10 1 REPLY

View 2 replies

I

5 months ago

This actually was a good movie

234 1 REPLY

View 9 replies

O

5 months ago

i LOVED this movie!!! sue me.

View 3 replies

Notions of control within 'the' community

Notions of being and wanting to remain invested



8 months ago

This is so much better than the official trailer, it actually makes the movie seem like it's going to be really good.

👍 32 🗨️ REPLY

View 5 replies ▾



8 months ago

Simply outstanding! Even more pumped for the movie.

👍 1 🗨️ REPLY



8 months ago

Hey every single movie studio trailer maker person. Take note. This is how you garner interest. This. Is. Awesome.

👍 59 🗨️ REPLY

View 2 replies ▾



8 months ago

Yes that is better.
It adds energy.
Just the "I'm Han Solo" one adds "Fun"

👍 2 🗨️ REPLY



8 months ago

This is so much better than the actual trailer!

👍 18 🗨️ REPLY

View reply ▾



8 months ago

This is how you sell this movie!

👍 10 🗨️ REPLY

View reply ▾



8 months ago

So this is JJ Abrams' influence coming full circle?

👍 2 🗨️ REPLY

View 2 replies ▾



8 months ago

Better than the official trailer. Got me way more stoked to see it! 👍

👍 1 🗨️ REPLY



8 months ago

If only the original trailer could give me goosebumps like this! Great Job!

👍 20 🗨️ REPLY



6 months ago

This trailer got me excited instead of the actual trailer.

👍 1 🗨️ REPLY

For many people, Star Wars matters. It is an entertainment commodity they are invested in. It allows them to make substantial experiences. Be affected, attuned, to coordinate personal and communal being. However, this does not mean that they can't be critical of it (and that it is the only means to do so).

Convergence culture has not only added tools to speak back to the dominant media culture and industry. But rather, it also offered tools to create and present the spectacle bottom up.

Not a balanced outcome, but a balancing one. Not to fully regain control by resistance, but rather to allow for the emergence of lifeways within contemporary capitalist ruins.

Thanks!

a.o.schellewald@sms.ed.ac.uk

References

Abbot, A. (2005). Linked Ecologies: States and Universities as Environments for Professions. In *Sociological Theory*, 23(3), 245-274.

Bannister, M.J. et al. (2013). Force-Directed Graph Drawing Using Social Gravity and Scaling. In W. Didimo and M. Patrignani eds., *Graph Drawing. GD 2012. Lecture Notes in Computer Science*, vol 7704. Berlin: Springer, 414-425.

Blondel, V.D. et al. (2008). Fast unfolding of communities in large networks. In *Journal of Statistical Mechanics*, P10008.

Breiger, R.L. (2007). Cultural Holes: Networks, Meanings, and Formal Practices. Paper presented at the American Sociological Association annual meeting, Culture Section anniversary session, New York.

Clough, P. and Halley, J. eds. (2007). *The Affective Turn: Theorizing the Social*. Durham: Duke University Press.

Deerwester, S.C. et al (1990). Indexing by latent semantic analysis. In *Journal of the American Society for Information Science*, 41(6), 391–407.

DiMaggio, P. et al. (2013). Exploiting affinities between topic modeling and the sociological perspective on culture. In *Poetics*, 41, 570-606.

Epstein, E.J. (2010). *The Hollywood Economist. The Hidden Financial Reality Behind the Movies*. New York: Melville House.

Fontdevila, J. et al. (2011). Order at the Edge of Chaos: Meanings from Netdom Switchings Across Functional Systems. In *Sociological Theory*, 29(3), 178-198.

Fuhse, J. (2009). The Meaning Structure of Social Networks. In *Sociological Theory*, 27(1), 51-73.

Fuhse, J. and Mützel, S. (2011). Tackling connections, structure, and meaning in networks: quantitative and qualitative methods in sociological network research. In *Qual Quant*, 45, 1067-1089.

Gumbrecht, H.U. and Pfeiffer, K.L. eds. (1994). *Materialities of Communication*. Stanford: Stanford University Press.

Gumbrecht, H.U. (1997). In 1926. *Living at the Edge of Time*. Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press.

Gumbrecht, H.U. (2004). *Production of Presence. What Meaning Cannot Convey*. Stanford: Stanford University Press.

Gumbrecht, H.U. (2013). *After 1945. Latency as Origin of the Present*. Stanford: Stanford University Press.

Gumbrecht, H.U. (2014). All that Matters is Invisible: How Latency Dominates our Present. Shulman Lecture Series in Science and the Humanities, April 8, Yale University.

Hansen, M. (2004a). The Time of Affect, or Bearing Witness to Life. In *Critical Inquiry*, 20, 584-626.

Hansen, M. (2004b). *New Philosophy for New Media*. Cambridge, MA: MIT Press.

Hansen, M. (2006). *Bodies in Code. Interfaces with Digital Media*. London: Routledge.

Hansen, M. (2015). *Feed-Forward. On the Future of Twenty-First-Century Media*. Chicago: University of Chicago Press.

Ikegami, E. (2000). A Sociological Theory of Publics. Identity and Culture as Emergent Properties in Networks. In *Social Research*, 67(4), 989-1029.

Ikegami, E. (2005). *Bonds of Civility: Aesthetic Networks and the Political Origins of Japanese Culture*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.

Lancichinetti, A. and Fortunato, S. (2011). Limits of modularity maximization in community detection. In *Physical Review*, 84, 066122.

Lewis, S.C. et al. (2013). Content Analysis in an Era of Big Data A Hybrid Approach to Computational and Manual Methods. In *Journal of Broadcasting & Electronic Media*, 57(1), 34-52.

Livingstone, S. (2018). Audiences in an age of datafication: critical questions for media research. In *Television and New Media*, accepted for publication.

Lucas, C. et al. (2015). Computer-Assisted Text Analysis for Comparative Politics. In *Political Analysis*, 25, 254-277.

Lund, K. and Burgess, C. (1996). Producing high-dimensional semantic spaces from lexical co-occurrence. In *Behavior Research Methods, Instruments, and Computers*, 28 (2), 203– 208.

MacKenzie, D. (2016). *How Algorithms Interact: Goffman's 'Interaction Order' in Automated Trading*. Manuscript.

Miheleca, R. and Tarau, P. (2004). TextRank Brining Order into Texts. In *Proceedings of the 2004 Conference on Empirical Methods in Natural Language Processing*.

Mützel, S. (2015). Facing Big Data: Making sociology relevant. In *Big Data & Society*, 1-4.

Mützel, S. (2009). Networks as Culturally Constituted Processes. A Comparison of Relational Sociology and Actor-network Theory. In *Current Sociology*, 57(6), 871-887.

Orman, G.K. et al. (2012). Comparative evaluation of community detection algorithms: a topological approach. In *Journal of Statistical Mechanics*, P08001.

Papadopoulos, S. et al. (2011). Community detection in Social Media. Performance and application considerations. In *Data Mining and Knowledge Discovery*, 24, 515-554.

Parisi, L. (2013). *Contagious Architecture, Computation, Aesthetics, and Space*. Cambridge MA: MIT Press.

Passoth, J.-H. (2017). Hardware, Software, Runtime. The politics of (at least) three digital materialities. IN *BEHEMOTH A Journal on Civilisation*, 10(1), 57-73.

Ritter, J. (1974). Landschaft. Zur Funktion des Ästhetischen in der modernen Gesellschaft. In J. Ritter, *Subjektivität. Sechs Aufsätze*. Frankfurt a.M.: Suhrkamp, 141-164.

Roberts, M.E. et al. (2013). The structural topic model and applied social science. In *Advances in Neural Information Processing Systems Workshop on Topic Models: Computation, Application, and Evaluation*.

Thevenot, L. (2012). The Invested Human Being: Four Extensions of the Notion of Engagement. In M. Archer and A. Maccarini, eds., *Engaging with the World: Agency, Institutions, Historical Formations*. London: Routledge.

Tsing, A. (2015). *The Mushroom at the End of the World. On the Possibility of Life in Capitalist Ruins*. Princeton: Princeton University Press.